BUSINESS TRIP CHEAT SHEET · 4 PAGES

Doing Business in Japan ビジネスマナー

The unwritten rules your Japanese partners will notice — on one page each. Print it, read it on the flight, and walk into your first meeting with confidence.

01 **Be 5 minutes early — not on time.**
Arriving exactly on time is considered slightly late.

02 **Bring 2–3× more business cards than you think.**
Everyone in the room exchanges cards with everyone.

03 **Treat a business card like the person.**
Never write on it, fold it, or put it in your back pocket.

04 **Wait to be seated.**
Seats have a rank. Your host will guide you (see page 3).

05 **Silence is not a problem.**
Pauses mean careful thinking. Don't rush to fill them.

06 **"We will consider it" often means no.**
Decisions are made later, by consensus — don't push for a yes in the room.

07 **Never pour your own drink.**
Pour for others; they will pour for you.

08 **Bring a small gift (omiyage).**
Something from your city, nicely wrapped (page 4).

09 **Don't tip.**
Not in restaurants, taxis or hotels. It can cause confusion.

10 **Send a thank-you email the same day.**
Templates in Japanese & English on page 4.

10 phrases that open doors 基本フレーズ

はじめまして	*Hajimemashite*	Nice to meet you (first meeting only)
よろしくお願いします	*Yoroshiku onegaishimasu*	I look forward to working with you — the most useful phrase in Japan
いつもお世話になっております	*Itsumo osewa ni natte orimasu*	Thank you for your continued support (opening of every business call/email)
ありがとうございます	*Arigatō gozaimasu*	Thank you (polite)
失礼します	*Shitsurei shimasu*	Excuse me — when entering/leaving a room
すみません	*Sumimasen*	Excuse me / sorry / thank you (all-purpose)
お疲れさまです	*Otsukaresama desu*	Greeting between colleagues — "thanks for your hard work"
乾杯！	*Kanpai!*	Cheers! (wait for the host to say it first)
いただきます	*Itadakimasu*	Said before eating
ごちそうさまでした	*Gochisōsama deshita*	Thank you for the meal — say it to your host when leaving

© Your Shop Name · For personal use

Business Cards & Bowing 名刺交換・お辞儀

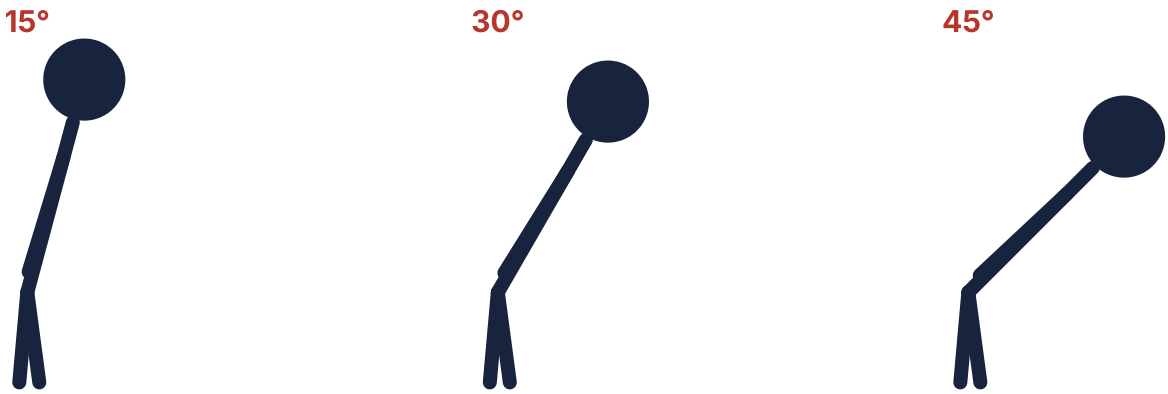
The card exchange (meishi kōkan) is the first impression. It takes 10 seconds and is watched closely.

The card exchange, step by step 名刺交換

1. **Stand up.** Never exchange cards seated or across a table — walk around it.
2. **Hold your card with both hands**, text facing the other person, at chest height.
3. **The visitor offers first**, and the junior person offers first. Say your company and name, then *"Yoroshiku onegaishimasu."*
4. **Hold your card slightly lower** than theirs — a small sign of respect.
5. **Receive with both hands** and say *"Chōdai itashimasu"* (I humbly receive it).
6. **Read it for a moment.** Check the name and title — it shows interest.
7. **Place it on the table**, on top of your card case, for the whole meeting. With several people, line the cards up in their seating order.
8. **Put it away carefully** when the meeting ends — into a card case, never a pocket.

- ✕ Writing notes on someone's card, playing with it, or leaving it behind on the table.
- ✕ Pulling a card from your wallet or back pocket. Use a card case.

Three bows to know お辞儀



Eshaku 会釈
Light bow. Passing someone in the hallway, entering a room.

Keirei 敬礼
Standard bow. Greeting clients, card exchange, saying thank you.

Saikeirei 最敬礼
Deep bow. Sincere apology or deep gratitude. Rare for visitors.

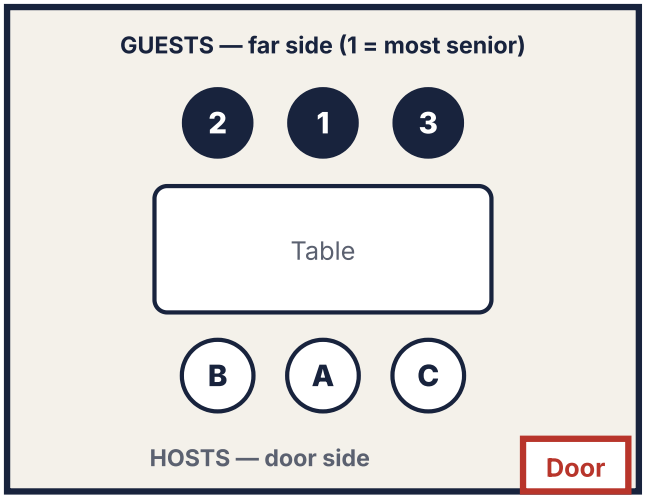
- ✓ Bow from the waist with a straight back; eyes look down, not at the other person.
- ✓ As a foreign visitor, a handshake is often offered — accept it, and add a small nod.
- ✓ When in doubt, match the depth of the other person's bow.

© Your Shop Name · For personal use

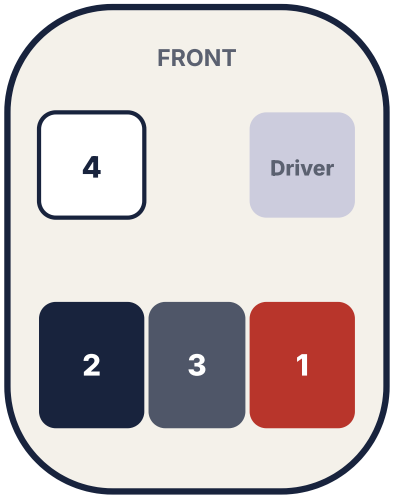
Seating Order & Dinners 上座・会食

Every room has a "top seat" (kamiza 上座) — the one farthest from the door. Guests and seniors sit there. The seat nearest the door (shimoza 下座) is for the most junior host.

Meeting room 会議室



Taxi タクシー



Left-hand traffic · driver on the right

Seat 1 is behind the driver. The front passenger seat is the lowest — the junior host sits there to pay and guide.
Exception: if your host drives their own car, the front seat next to them is the top seat.

At the dinner table 会食・飲み会

- ✓ Wait for the host's *"Kanpai!"* before drinking anything.
- ✓ When clinking glasses with a senior person, hold yours slightly lower.
- ✓ Watch others' glasses and refill them. Hold the bottle with both hands.
- ✓ When someone pours for you, lift your glass with both hands.
- ✓ Want to stop drinking? Leave your glass full.

- × Pouring your own drink.
- × Sticking chopsticks upright in rice, or passing food chopstick-to-chopstick (both are funeral customs).
- × Blowing your nose at the table.
- × Fighting over the bill. If invited, the host pays — thank them the next day.

Not sure where to sit? Stand near the door and wait. Your host will gesture and say 「どうぞ、こちらへ」 *Dōzo, kochira e* — "Please, this way." Accept once; if you're offered the top seat, it's polite to sit there.

© Your Shop Name · For personal use

Gifts & Thank-You Emails 手土産・お礼メール

Choosing an omiyage 手土産

- ✓ **Local & edible:** chocolates, cookies, maple syrup, coffee — something from your city or state.
- ✓ **Individually wrapped** pieces, so it can be shared around the office.
- ✓ **$20–50** for a team gift. Bring an extra one for unexpected meetings.
- ✓ Give it at the **end** of the meeting, with both hands, out of its shopping bag.

- × Sets of **4 or 9** items — the words sound like "death" and "suffering".
- × Knives or scissors — they suggest "cutting ties".
- × Very expensive gifts — they create an obligation to give back.
- × Black-and-white ribbons or wrapping (used for funerals).

Say: **「ささやかですが、どうぞ」** *Sasayaka desu ga, dōzo* — "It's just a small something, please."

Same-day thank-you email お礼メール

Copy, replace the **[brackets]**, and send. Japanese partners will appreciate the effort, even if they reply in English.

件名：本日のお打ち合わせのお礼

Subject: Thank you for today's meeting

[会社名] [部署名]
[相手の名前] 様
[Company] [Department] — Mr./Ms. [Name] ("sama" = respectful title)

いつも大変お世話になっております。
[自分の会社名]の[自分の名前]です。
Thank you for your continued support. This is [your name] from [your company].

本日はお忙しい中、貴重なお時間をいただき、誠にありがとうございました。
Thank you very much for taking valuable time out of your busy schedule today.

[話し合った内容]について、引き続き検討を進めてまいります。
We will continue to move forward on [topic we discussed].

今後ともどうぞよろしくお願いいたします。
We look forward to continuing to work with you.

After you fly home 帰国後

- ✓ Send the thank-you email within 24 hours.
- ✓ Note each person's name, title and seat from the cards you collected.
- ✓ Share any photos taken together.
- ✓ Next visit, open with: **「先日はありがとうございました」** *Senjitsu wa arigatō gozaimashita* — "Thank you for the other day."

© Your Shop Name · For personal use